

DEMO HEALTH NETWORK

CIRCULAR C-2026-11

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Subject: Sepsis antibiotic timing - risk-stratified targets

Circular number: C-2026-11 Version: 1

Date of issue: 2026-09-08 Effective from: 2026-09-15

Amends: P-ED-01 section 5.3

1 BACKGROUND

A network audit of 1,240 adult sepsis presentations found that giving antibiotics within one hour to every patient with possible sepsis led to unnecessary broad-spectrum antibiotic use in patients later found not to have an infection. The Sepsis Working Group has approved risk-stratified antibiotic timing targets.

2 AMENDMENT

Section 5.3 of P-ED-01 (Sepsis Recognition and One-Hour Bundle, version 2) is replaced with effect from 15 September 2026 by the following:

- (a) Probable sepsis or septic shock: give broad-spectrum intravenous antibiotics within 1 hour of recognition.
- (b) Possible sepsis without shock: complete a senior clinical assessment and give antibiotics within 3 hours of recognition if infection remains the likely cause.
- (c) Record the time of the first antibiotic dose on the sepsis screening form.

3 CONTACT

Emergency Department clinical lead, extension 3105.

Signed: Chair, Sepsis Working Group (synthetic)